Venetoclax and obinutuzumab

Venetoclax and obinutuzumab is a cancer drug treatment. It is used to treat some types of blood cancer.

On this page

- What is venetoclax and obinutuzumab?
- How venetoclax and obinutuzumab is given
- About side effects
- Side effects while treatment is being given
- Very common side effects
- Other side effects
- Other important information
- How we can help

What is venetoclax and obinutuzumab?

Venetoclax and obinutuzumab is a combination of 2 targeted therapy drugs. It is used to treat:

- chronic lymphocytic leukaemia (CLL)
- small lymphocytic lymphoma (SLL).

Venetoclax is also called Venclyxto®. Obinutuzumab is also called Gazyvaro®.

It is best to read this information with our general information about cancer drug treatments and the type of cancer you have.

Your cancer team will talk to you about this treatment and its possible side effects before you agree (consent) to have treatment.

More information about this treatment

This information is correct at time of publishing. But sometimes the types of cancer this treatment is used for, or treatment side effects, may change between revision dates.

You can talk to your cancer team if you want more detailed information about this treatment. Or visit the electronic Medicines Compendium (eMC) website, which has patient information leaflets (PIL) for individual drugs.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/venetoclax-and-obinutuzumab · retrieved 26 October 2026

How venetoclax and obinutuzumab is given

You have obinutuzumab as a drip into a vein (intravenously). You may have this in a day unit or clinic as an outpatient. Or you may have it during a stay in hospital. Venetoclax comes as tablets that you can take at home.

During your course of treatment, you will meet someone from your cancer team, such as a:

- cancer doctor
- chemotherapy nurse or specialist nurse
- specialist pharmacist.

This is who we mean when we mention doctor, nurse or pharmacist in this information.

During your course of treatment, you will have regular blood tests. This is to check that it is safe for you to have treatment.

You will meet with a doctor, nurse or pharmacist before you have treatment. They will talk to you about your blood test results and ask how you have been feeling. If your blood test results are okay, the pharmacy team will prepare your cancer drugs.

Your course of treatment

You usually have a course of several cycles of treatment over a few months. Each cycle lasts 28 days (4 weeks).

Cycle 1, you usually:

- have obinutuzumab - on day 1, 2, 8 and 15
- start taking venetoclax on day 22 and gradually increase the dose.

From cycle 2 to cycle 6, you usually:

- have obinutuzumab - on day 1 only
- take venetoclax every day.

From cycle 7 to cycle 12, you only take venetoclax.

This treatment can cause a condition called tumour lysis syndrome (TLS). To help prevent TLS, your cancer team will give you advice about how much to drink. They may also give you drugs and extra fluids through a drip when you start treatment and as the dose of venetoclax is increasing. You can read more about the symptoms of TLS in the section Other side effects.

Your cancer team will discuss your treatment plan with you. They may give you a copy of the plan to take home.

You will be given the venetoclax tablets to take at home. Your cancer team may give you tablets of different strengths. Always take them exactly as they tell you to. This is important to make sure the tablets work as well as possible for you.

Your cancer team will also give you other medicines to prevent side effects that you may need to take at home. Take all your capsules or tablets exactly as they tell you to.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/venetoclax-and-obinutuzumab · retrieved 26 October 2026

Having obinutuzumab

Your nurse will give the obinutuzumab drip through 1 of the following:

- a cannula – a short, thin tube the nurse puts into a vein in your arm or hand
- a central line – a fine tube that goes under the skin of your chest and into a vein close by
- a PICC line – a fine tube that is put into a vein in your arm and goes up into a vein in your chest
- an implantable port (portacath) – a disc that is put under the skin on your chest or arm and goes into a vein in your chest.

They will explain how long your treatment is likely to take.

Taking venetoclax tablets

You take venetoclax tablets once a day. You start on a low dose. The dose is gradually increased. This helps to reduce the risk of a side effect called tumour lysis syndrome (TLS). You can read more about the symptoms of TLS in the section Other side effects.

You have blood tests more often when you first start taking venetoclax. This is to check whether it is safe to continue treatment. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will tell you when your blood will be checked.

Take the tablets with or after food. Swallow them whole with a glass of water. Do not chew, break or crush them. Try to take them at the same time every day.

If you forget to take the tablets, you can take the missed dose up to 8 hours later. If you miss a dose by more than 8 hours, just take the next dose at the usual time. Do not take a double dose. Contact the hospital on the 24hr number if you are not sure what to do.

If you are sick (vomit) just after taking them, do not take an extra dose. Take your next dose at the usual time.

During your treatment, you should avoid grapefruit, star fruit (carambola) and Seville oranges. This is because they can affect how venetoclax works and may make side effects worse. You should avoid:

- drinking the juice of these fruits
- eating food that contains them
- taking supplements that might contain them.

Other things to remember about your tablets:

- Keep them in the original package and at room temperature, away from moisture, heat and direct sunlight.
- Keep them safe, where children cannot see or reach them.
- Do not throw away unused tablets. Return them to your cancer team at the hospital.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/venetoclax-and-obinutuzumab · retrieved 26 October 2026

About side effects

We explain the most common side effects of this treatment here. We also include some that are less common.

You may get some of the side effects we mention, but you are unlikely to get all of them. And you may have some side effects, including rarer ones, that we have not listed here.

Always tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist about any side effects you have. They can give you:

- drugs to help control some side effects
- advice about managing side effects.

It is important to take any drugs exactly as explained. This means they will be more likely to work for you.

Serious and life-threatening side effects

Some cancer treatments can cause serious side effects. Sometimes, these may be life-threatening. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can explain the risk of these side effects to you.

Contact the hospital

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will give you 24-hour contact numbers for the hospital. If you feel unwell or need advice, you can call at any time of the day or night. Save these numbers in your phone or keep them somewhere safe.

Side effects while treatment is being given

Some people have side effects while they are having obinutuzumab or shortly after they have it.

Allergic reaction

Some people have an allergic reaction while having this treatment. The first infusion is the most likely to cause a reaction, so it is usually given more slowly than later treatments. Before treatment, you will have medicines to help prevent or reduce any reaction.

Signs of a reaction can include:

- feeling hot or flushed
- shivering
- itching
- a skin rash
- feeling dizzy or sick
- a headache
- feeling breathless or wheezy

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/venetoclax-and-obinutuzumab · retrieved 26 October 2026

- swelling of your face or mouth
- pain in your back, tummy or chest.

Your nurse will check you for signs of a reaction during your infusion. If you feel unwell or have any of these signs, tell them straight away. If you do have a reaction, they can treat it quickly.

Sometimes a reaction happens a few hours after treatment. If you develop any of these signs or feel unwell after you get home, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number.

Always call 999 if swelling happens suddenly or you are struggling to breathe.

Very common side effects

These side effects happen to 10 or more people in every 100 people (10% or more) who have this treatment.

Risk of infection

This treatment can reduce the number of white blood cells in your blood. These cells fight infection. If your white blood cell count is low, you may be more likely to get an infection. A low white blood cell count is called neutropenia.

An infection can be very serious when the number of white blood cells is low. Your doctor may give you antibiotics and other drugs to take during this treatment. These may help reduce your risk of getting an infection.

But it is still important to get any infection treated as soon as possible. If you have any of the following symptoms, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number:

- a temperature above 37.5°C
- a temperature below 36°C
- you feel unwell, even with a normal temperature
- you have symptoms of an infection.

Symptoms of an infection include:

- feeling shivery and shaking
- a sore throat
- a cough
- breathlessness
- diarrhoea
- needing to pass urine (pee) often, or discomfort when you pass urine.

It is important to follow any specific advice your cancer treatment team gives you.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/venetoclax-and-obinutuzumab · retrieved 26 October 2026

Your white blood cell count will usually return to normal before your next treatment. You will have a blood test before having more treatment. If your white blood cell count is low, your doctor may delay your treatment for a short time, until your cell count increases.

You may be given a drug called G-CSF. This encourages the body to make more white blood cells. You have it as a small injection under the skin.

Bruising and bleeding

This treatment can reduce the number of platelets in your blood. Platelets are cells that help the blood to clot.

If the number of platelets is low, you may bruise or bleed easily. You may have:

- nosebleeds
- bleeding gums
- heavy periods
- blood in your urine (pee) or stools (poo)
- tiny red, brown or purple spots that may look like a rash – these spots can be harder to see if you have black or brown skin.

If you have any unexplained bruising or bleeding, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number. You may need a drip to give you extra platelets. This is called a platelet transfusion.

Anaemia (low number of red blood cells)

This treatment can reduce the number of red blood cells in your blood. Red blood cells carry oxygen around the body. If the number of red blood cells is low, this is called anaemia. You may feel:

- very low in energy
- breathless
- dizzy and light-headed.

If you have these symptoms, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number. You may need treatment for anaemia. If you are very anaemic, you may need a drip to give you extra red blood cells. This is called a blood transfusion.

Diarrhoea

This treatment may cause diarrhoea. Diarrhoea means passing more stools (poo) than is normal for you, or having watery or loose stools. You may also have stomach cramps. If you have a stoma, it may be more active than usual.

If you are passing loose stools 3 or more times a day and this is not normal for you, contact the hospital as soon as possible on the 24-hour number. Follow the advice they give you about:

- taking anti-diarrhoea medicines
- drinking enough fluids to keep you hydrated and to replace lost salts and minerals
- any changes to your diet that might help.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/venetoclax-and-obinutuzumab · retrieved 26 October 2026

They might also ask you for a specimen of your stool to check for infection.

Feeling sick

You may feel sick during this treatment, but this is usually mild. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist may prescribe you anti-sickness drugs to help prevent or control sickness. Take the drugs exactly as they tell you to. If you feel sick, take small sips of fluid often and eat small amounts regularly. It is important to drink enough fluids.

If you continue to feel sick, or if you are sick (vomit) 1 to 2 times in 24 hours, contact the hospital on the 24-hour number as soon as possible. They will give you advice.

Feeling tired

Feeling tired is a common side effect of this treatment. Try to pace yourself and plan your day so you have time to rest. Gentle exercise, like short walks, can help you feel less tired.

If you feel sleepy, do not drive or use machinery.

Constipation

This treatment can cause constipation. Constipation means that you are not able to pass stools (poo) as often as you normally do. It can become difficult or painful. Here are some tips that may help:

- Drink at least 2 litres (3½ pints) of fluids each day.
- Eat high-fibre foods, such as fruit, vegetables and wholemeal bread.
- Do regular gentle exercise, like going for short walks.

If you have constipation, contact the hospital on the 24-hour number for advice. They can give you drugs called laxatives to help.

If you have not been able to pass stools for over 2 days and are being sick, contact the 24-hour number straight away.

Other side effects

These side effects happen to less than 10 in 100 people (less than 10%) who have this treatment. Some of them are much rarer than this but they are still important to know about. Rare means a side effect that happens to less than 1 in 1,000 people (less than 0.1%).

Tumour lysis syndrome (TLS)

This treatment can cause a condition called tumour lysis syndrome (TLS). TLS happens when cancer treatment makes large numbers of cancer cells die and break down quickly. This releases lots of waste products into the blood and can affect the kidneys and heart.

The risk is highest when you start treatment. You will have regular blood tests to check for TLS. Your cancer team will explain things that can help prevent this condition.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/venetoclax-and-obinutuzumab · retrieved 26 October 2026

Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour contact number if you have any of the following symptoms of TLS. Do not take any more venetoclax without their advice:

- feeling very hot (feverish) or having chills
- feeling or being sick (vomit)
- pain in your joints or muscles
- feeling breathless or having an irregular heartbeat
- dark or cloudy urine (pee)
- feeling confused
- pain or swelling in your tummy (abdomen)
- fits or seizures.

You can read more about preventing TLS in our information about side effects above.

Effects on the heart

This treatment can affect how the heart works. You may have tests to check how well your heart is working. These may be done before, during and after treatment.

If the treatment is causing heart problems, your doctor may change the type of treatment you are having.

Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number if you have any of these symptoms during or after treatment:

- breathlessness
- dizziness
- changes to your heartbeat (palpitations)
- swollen feet and ankles.

Other conditions can cause these symptoms, but it is important to get them checked by a doctor.

Always call **999** if you have:

- chest pain, pressure, heaviness, tightness or squeezing across the chest
- difficulty breathing.

Effects on the brain

Rarely, this treatment causes a brain condition that can be serious. This can cause:

- a headache that does not get better
- drowsiness or confusion
- changes in eyesight
- trouble speaking
- difficulty walking
-

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/venetoclax-and-obinutuzumab · retrieved 26 October 2026

fits (seizures).

If you have any of these symptoms, it is important to either:

- contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number
- go to the hospital straight away.

You should not drive yourself to hospital.

Other important information

Blood clot risk

Cancer and some cancer treatments can increase the risk of a blood clot. Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number if you have any of these symptoms during or after treatment:

- throbbing pain or swelling in a leg or arm
- reddening of the skin in the area – if you have black or brown skin, this can be harder to notice, but the skin might become darker
- suddenly feeling breathless or coughing.

Always call **999** if you have:

- chest pain
- difficulty breathing.

A blood clot is serious, but it can be treated with drugs called anticoagulants. These thin the blood. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you more information about preventing and treating blood clots.

Other medicines

Some medicines can affect how this treatment works or be harmful while you are having it. Always tell your cancer doctor, nurse or pharmacist about any drugs you are taking or planning to take, such as:

- medicines you have been prescribed
- medicines you buy in a shop, pharmacy or online
- vitamins or supplements
- herbal drugs and complementary or homeopathic therapies
- recreational drugs – for example, cannabis.

Vaccinations

Cancer doctors usually recommend that people with cancer have vaccinations for flu and coronavirus (covid). They may also recommend other vaccines, such as Shingrix® for shingles. These all help reduce your risk of serious illness from these infections. Most people can have these vaccines, including people with weak immune systems.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/venetoclax-and-obinutuzumab · retrieved 26 October 2026

You should not have live vaccines if your immune system is weak. This includes if you are having or recently had chemotherapy, radiotherapy or other cancer treatments that affect your immune system. Live vaccines can make you unwell because they contain a very weak version of the illness they protect you against. There are several live vaccines, including the yellow fever vaccine.

It is important to ask your doctor, nurse or pharmacist for advice about having vaccinations. They can explain what vaccines are right for you and when it is best to have them.

Contraception

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will advise you not to get pregnant or make someone pregnant while having this treatment and for some time afterwards. The drugs may harm a developing baby. It is important to use contraception to prevent pregnancy. Follow their advice about:

- what types of contraception to use
- how long after treatment you should continue to use contraception.

Breastfeeding

You are advised not to breastfeed while having this treatment, or for some time after treatment ends. This is because the drugs could be passed to the baby through breast milk.

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you more information.

Fertility

Some cancer drugs can affect whether you can get pregnant or make someone pregnant. If you are worried about this, it is important to talk with your doctor before you start treatment.

Medical and dental treatment

If you need medical treatment for any reason other than cancer, always tell the healthcare professional that you are having cancer treatment. Give them the contact details for your cancer doctor or cancer team so they can ask for advice.

If you have appointments with a dentist, always tell them you are having cancer treatment. Talk to your cancer team before you have any dental treatment.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References

Visit the electronic Medicines Compendium (eMC) to download a Patient Information Leaflet (PIL) for more detailed information. The leaflet lists all known side effects.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/venetoclax-and-obinutuzumab · retrieved 26 October 2026

Cancer Information Development team

Author

Date reviewed

Reviewed: 01 February 2026 | Next review: 01 February 2028

Our cancer information meets the PIF TICK quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about how we produce our information.

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as ‘you’ so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms ‘men’ and ‘women’ or ‘male’ and ‘female’. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information here.

How we can help

How to print a PDF from this website

Instructions on how you can make a PDF version of this page using the print function on your browser.

Macmillan Support Line

The Macmillan Support Line is a free and confidential service for people living with and affected by cancer. If you need to talk, we'll listen.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/venetoclax-and-obinutuzumab · retrieved 26 October 2026

Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.

Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don’t want to call.

Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.

Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/venetoclax-and-obinutuzumab · retrieved 26 October 2026